

ANIMACY AND AGENCY FOR EARTH BEINGS: HOW ANISHINAABE WRITERS PROMOTE INCLUSIVE CLIMATE CHANGE NARRATIVES

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Abstract

As the climate crisis becomes an increasingly urgent global issue, we argue that it is crucial to consider alternative climate narratives to the dominant Western anthropocentric framework. In our paper, we study literature from the Anishinaabe peoples, a group of culturally and linguistically related Indigenous nations located in the Great Lakes region of North America. The primary objective of our research is to identify literary techniques that Anishinaabe writers employed to promote an inclusive narrative of the climate crisis. Through close reading and critical analysis, we examine how Anishinaabe writers portray “earth beings,” such as animals and plants, typically considered inferior by Western thinking. We argue that contemporary Anishinaabe authors employ literary techniques to advance themes of animacy and agency, offering an alternative understanding of the environment and interspecies relationships. By portraying earth beings as spiritual, autonomous, and powerful, Anishinaabe literary works further a system of thought that values all species equally. Our research advocates for the incorporation of literary methods used by Anishinaabe peoples so as to reframe Western perceptions of inanimacy.

Keywords

Anishinaabe literature, anthropocentrism, interspecies relationships, agency, animacy, Indigenous storytelling

I. Introduction

Ecocentrism is a worldview that recognizes the inherent value present in all life forms and ecosystems, including nonliving beings (Washington et al. 35). It stands in contrast to anthropocentrism, which emphasizes the central importance of humans and only values other life forms and abiotic elements insofar as their contributions to human interests. Our research is centered around examining

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techniques in Anishinaabe literature used to perpetuate a more ecocentric view of climate change in which humans are not the central focus but a smaller piece within the ecosystem.

Indigenous storytelling is vastly different from Western ecological narratives, specifically in its approaches to interspecies relationships and hierarchies (Zak 5-7). However, centuries of European colonialism and exploitation have obscured these diverse and powerful Indigenous narratives founded upon Traditional Ecological Knowledge, or TEK (Watts 32). TEK is the cumulative collection of Indigenous knowledge and practices rooted in generations of experiences with the environment. Despite the disproportionate impacts of climate change on Indigenous communities (Whyte 154-155), Western institutions continue to perpetuate an anthropocentric narrative of the climate crisis, omitting valuable Indigenous perspectives and knowledge. As climate change becomes an increasingly pertinent and urgent reality, we investigate narrative techniques in Indigenous literature to identify how they are used to create a more ecocentric narrative of the climate crisis.

The term “earth beings” refers to humans, animals, plants, and geophysical features. This term was first coined by Marisol de la Cadena, who is a Professor of Anthropology at the University of California, Davis. Although de la Cadena defines earth beings as sentient and willful geophysical features, such as mountains and rivers (de la Cadena 13), we consider all living creatures, including animals, humans, plants, and geological features, as earth beings. By using the all-inclusive term “earth beings,” we avoid categorizations such as “non-humans,” eliminating human superiority that is embedded in language.

In our paper, we explore how Anishinaabe authors harness specific storytelling techniques to promote a more ecocentric and less exploitative narrative of the earth/ecosystem. Specifically, we explore themes of animacy, the state of being alive and animate, and agency, which refers to the capacity to make independent decisions. After critically analyzing Anishinaabe literature and stories from the late 20th to 21st century, we found that contemporary Anishinaabe writers use the authority of animals, the animacy of whirlwinds, and the agency of plants to create alternative narratives of the earth, which contrast predominant Western anthropocentric frameworks.

This paper is structured according to our three primary sources: *The Mishomis Book: The Voice of the Ojibway*, *The Gift is in the Making*, and *Braiding Sweetgrass*. In each section, we perform close reading and critical literary analysis to examine the sources for literary elements that propose alternative narratives to the current portrayal of climate change.

II. Literature Review

The dominant narrative of climate change is founded upon anthropocentrism, with humans at the heart of the crisis. This portrayal does not consider earth beings such as animals, rivers, and plants as active agents in the climate crisis in any significant way. This narrative stems from European colonialism, which is founded on the goal to “master the land, use it, and derive bounty from it,” an ideology that juxtaposes Anishinaabe beliefs of the agency of the land and earth beings (Lahti, 65). Expounding upon this idea, Alison Sealey contends in “Animals, animacy and anthropocentrism” that the English language takes for granted the distinction between humans and nonhumans, stripping nonhumans of individuality and autonomy. She argues that human exceptionalism has resulted in the absence of valuable animal perspectives on animacy discourses. As an alternative to this thought pattern based on the English language, Robin Wall Kimmerer’s “Conversing with Nature: The Linguistic Roots of Environmental Consciousness” argues that the Potawatomi pronoun “ki” is superior to its English counterpart “it.” “Ki” expands the scope of animacy to living and spiritual beings, establishing a tone of respect and inclusivity with the environment. Kimmerer claims that by connecting earth beings through “ki,” it becomes harder to justify exploitative efforts towards nonhuman earth beings because they are no longer seen as inanimate objects or resources meant for human consumption.



Figure 1: Diego Valadés, The Great Chain of Being, 1579. Woodcut illustration from *Rhetorica Christiana*.

In contrast with Kimmerer’s inclusivity of all species, fig. 1 demonstrates a clear separation and hierarchy between species. It depicts the dominant hierarchy of beings in the Western worldview. The image organizes beings with God at the top, followed by angels, humans, animals, and plants, and finally inanimate matter such as rocks and minerals at the bottom. Renaissance naturalists constructed this hierarchy of beings through a combination of Christian and Aristotelian philosophies. They conceived the ranking and categorization of species to allow humans to “... behold all that are below, and make them all serviceable to the quiet and peace and plenty of a Man’s life” (Lovejoy 232). This view of the natural world only considers nonhuman earth beings insofar as they benefit humanity.

In “Indigenous Place-Thought & Agency Amongst Humans and Non-Humans,” Vanessa Watts claims that land is alive, can think for itself, and holds agency. The land’s ability to think and feel in turn grants agency to all earth beings. She claims that colonialism separated Indigenous peoples from the land to which they were physically and spiritually a part of, and compares Indigenous world views with

the Euro-Western epistemological-ontological framework. This Western framework posits that knowledge can be acquired through reason and observation, and emphasizes humans' superior position within the order of existence. Watts argues that while the Euro-Western framework limits agency to humans because of our will and purpose, Indigenous systems view nonhuman earth beings as active entities able to influence and shape the actions of others. The separation of these two frameworks continues to exist today, as evident in "The New Materialisms and Indigenous Theories of Non-Human Agency: Making the Case for Respectful Anti-Colonial Engagement." Rosiek et al. argue that there has been a lack of engagement between Western social scientists and Indigenous scholars in studying the agency of earth beings. They assert that Western scholars must engage respectfully with Indigenous literature, or risk reinforcing the erasure and suppression of Indigenous cultures and knowledge systems.

There is inherent worth in engaging Indigenous scholars' ideas and opinions: Kyle Whyte's article "Indigenous Climate Change Studies: Indigenizing Futures, Decolonizing the Anthropocene" posits that the renewal of Indigenous knowledge systems is necessary for Indigenous communities to adjust to the effects of climate change. He calls for scientists to work collaboratively with Indigenous communities rather than exploitatively. Whyte also posits that colonialism disrupted Indigenous societies that were well-prepared to adapt to environmental change, increasing Indigenous vulnerability to the climate crisis. His claim ties back to Watts' argument that colonialism separated indigenous communities from the lands they were spiritually connected to, therefore disrupting their ability to communicate with their land and endangering their agency.

In "Combatting the Climate Crisis: Anishinaabe Philosophy and Environmental Justice," Margaret Hunt claims that the teachings of the Anishinaabe often emphasize humanity's need for nature in order to survive. Therefore, it is not only the knowledge of the Anishinaabe but also their philosophy that has promoted eco-conscious ways of living. Amba Sepie supports this argument in "More than Stories, More than Myths: Animal/Human/Nature(s) in Traditional Ecological Worldviews", by positing that Indigenous groups' understanding of reciprocal human-nonhuman relationships offers a more ecologically responsible approach to living. Through analyzing and understanding Anishinaabe literature, we explore how writers convey eco-conscious concepts through narrative techniques.

III. Methodology and Positionality Statement

Our research design employs qualitative literary analysis methods. We use critical literary analysis to examine the literary devices, themes, and overall implications of each primary source. We

also apply thematic analysis to understand patterns, in order to reveal their significance within Anishinaabe culture. Lastly, we utilize discourse analysis to survey the underlying ideas, assumptions, and power structures in language. Specifically, we look into the difference between Anishinaabe literature and Euro-Western narratives in their representation of animacy and agency.

We analyzed three primary texts: *The Mishomis Book: The Voice of the Ojibway* by Edward Benton-Banai, *The Gift is in the Making: Anishinaabeg Stories* by Leanne Betasamosake Simpson, and *Braiding Sweetgrass* by Robin Wall Kimmerer. Each source is written for a different age group, showcasing the wide reach of Anishinaabe authors. We analyze the spirit within beings, reciprocal relationships, personification, and colloquial language to show how themes of animacy and agency promote a worldview that recognizes the intrinsic value of all beings.

In reading and interpreting Indigenous literature, we acknowledge our limitations as non-Indigenous researchers. There was no involvement of Anishinaabe-affiliated scholars at any stage of this research. Therefore, we try our best to accurately represent Anishinaabe literature and knowledge through the following guidelines: choosing silence rather than misconstruction, practicing self-reflection, dealing in the purviews of non-Natives, and presenting only tentative, qualified, and provisional statements (McKegney, 58-63). We also recognize that there exists a myriad of diverse cultures and communities under the Anishinaabe peoples, such as the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Potawatomi, and we are providing a limited representation of these cultures.

IV. Analysis

1. *The Mishomis Book: Kinship and Autonomy of Earth Beings*

Edward Benton-Banai's children's book *The Mishomis Book: The Voice of the Ojibway* is the first in its series, detailing central stories of the Ojibwe. The narrative of this book progresses from the Original Man named Anishinaabe to the journey of Waynaboozhoo, then the migration of the Ojibwe, and ends with the subsequent European invasion. Throughout Waynaboozhoo's adventures, he speaks with and learns from earth beings. One story focuses on a game of chase between Waynaboozhoo and the whirlwind spirit. The whirlwind teases Waynaboozhoo and teaches him the importance of balance in life. The whirlwind explains that the Creator gave him the purpose "to tease those who take themselves too seriously" (54). Another story we analyzed was Waynaboozhoo's encounter with a buffalo. Waynaboozhoo was en route to the residence of his father when he encountered a dangerous region. He

was unable to pass through the area until he earned the respect of a great buffalo and received help from it. Benton-Banai's characterization of nonhuman earth beings as having personalities, relationships, and wisdom reinforces the idea that they deserve respect.

Benton-Banai depicts all earth beings as having a spirit with purpose, knowledge, and relationships, giving voices and agency to all entities that populate the Earth. The whirlwind introduces himself, saying, "I am wind ... but I am spirit also. The Creator has placed spirits everywhere. There are spirits in the rocks. There are spirits in the water. All of us spirits are an extension to Gitchie Manito [the Creator] ..." (Benton-Banai 54). A notable aspect is Benton-Banai's portrayal of the whirlwind's speech. The whirlwind is shown to be a living being, a spirit with the ability to develop and express their thoughts. In using the pronoun "us" to refer to all spirits, Benton-Banai indicates the relationship between different spirits—they are a collective extension of the Creator. Additionally, in Anishinaabe tradition, human children must be announced to the spirits in order to gain acceptance and recognition from the Spirit World (9). This relationship between spirits and humans shows how spirits have an interconnected network with one another and are not isolated, passive agents. Additionally, this ceremony rejects typical Western power dynamics because humans are trying to gain acceptance, as opposed to humans making an assumption of their own superiority.

Benton-Banai's characters often refer to other beings as kin, and he portrays nonhuman earth beings with power over humans, illustrating the importance of nonhuman earth being agency. The whirlwind tells Waynaboozhoo, "'I am brother to the Gee-zhee-ba-sun' (tornado). I am brother to the waterspout of the oceans and seas. Their power is my power and my power is theirs. My brothers choose to destroy and, thus, demonstrate the awesome powers of the Creation. I love to tease instead..." (52). Additionally, Waynaboozhoo and the narrator repeatedly speak of beings such as bears and plants as 'Older Brother' or "Brothers and Sisters" (42; 87). This kinship is not a connection by blood, but rather their connection to one another and shared inhabitancy of their environment. In illustrating this relationship, Benton-Banai furthers the Ojibwe's belief that all earth beings are deeply connected like family. In selecting the words "choose" and "love" to reference the actions of the whirlwind's brother, Benton-Banai demonstrates the autonomy of the waterspout and the tornado; the liberty to choose and the ability to fulfill that choice is a demonstration of the whirlwind's power. This liberty based depiction is uncommon in Western narratives that often describe nonhuman earth beings as reacting to shifts in the environment, rather than having the will to choose their course of action. In the phrase "I love to tease instead," the author also communicates the whirlwind's personality and preference, portraying the

whirlwind as a playful character, in contrast to his siblings. Giving the wind character and identity animates the wind and gives it autonomy, placing it in contrast to Western stories that usually describe the flow of air as it relates to the physical experience of human characters. Further, the word “brother” establishes a kinship among earth beings. The whirlwind’s speech gives depth to their character and demonstrates their wisdom, portraying the wind as a being worthy of respect.

Another passage that highlights themes of kinship and autonomy is the encounter of the buffalo and Waynaboozhoo, in which Waynaboozhoo earns the buffalo’s recognition and gains passage through a particularly dangerous terrain. The buffalo says, “I see that we cannot dissuade you from continuing your journey. Since you seem determined, I will walk beside you and guide you for a ways. Across these plains the winds blow very strong.... Only I am able to survive. If this happens stand at my side and I shall protect you. I will do this because I am one of your oldest brothers....” (39-40). In writing of Waynaboozhoo’s need for the buffalo’s guidance, Benton-Banai once again demonstrates the power dynamic between earth beings: all earth beings are on equal standings. This excerpt is one of many that reveal humans’ reliance on other beings, opposing Western stories where humans are seen as the dominant species. Additionally, the buffalo points out the kinship between Waynaboozhoo and himself, stating that as an older brother of Waynaboozhoo, he has an obligation to protect him. Benton-Banai’s portrayal of this interspecies relationship connects humans and nonhuman earth beings, placing equal value on both species rather than centering one over the other. In this quote, Benton-Banai breathes personality and authority into an earth being, seemingly granting the buffalo a higher status than Waynaboozhoo, a human-spirit.

In summary, Benton-Banai’s characters exhibit many traits that Western dominant culture typically reserves for humans. His pieces present earth beings with the capacity for relationships, purpose, and thought. In recognizing the spirit, kinship, autonomy, and personality of different earth beings, Benton-Banai empowers these beings and shows their existences as worthy of the same respect one would give their own brother.

2. *The Gift Is in the Making: Personification and Power in Anishinaabe Short Stories*

Leanne Betasamosake Simpson’s book *The Gift Is in the Making: Anishinaabeg Stories* is a collection of retellings of Anishinaabeg stories tailored to early adolescents. Each brief and accessible narrative aims to impart Anishinaabeg teachings and values to a younger generation. The book is interspersed with Anishnaabemowin, a language spoken by many Anishinaabe peoples, as well as

explanations of the words to help readers better understand the language. We analyze two short stories: “Good Neighbours” and “The Gift Is in the Making.” In the book, the Anishinaabe peoples are referred to as “Nishnaabeg,” which is simply an alternative spelling. “Good Neighbours” tells the story of the Nishnaabeg getting new neighbors who are loud, disrespectful, and careless. These neighbors also pollute the environment with machinery and technology. “The Gift Is in the Making” follows Nanabush, a spiritual being. When Nanabush tries to visit his friends, the Nishnaabeg, he is unable to find them. Bewildered, Nanabush scours the forest until he finds them drinking maple syrup from maple trees in the forest. The passages and scenes exemplify how Simpson’s storytelling challenges Western frameworks that view nature as passive and powerless. Simpson’s use of personification, direct speech, and active voice portrays earth beings as powerful, wise, and worthy of respect, reinforcing the animacy and agency of all earth beings.

Simpson uses personification and anthropomorphism through direct voice and pronouns to assign agency to nonhuman earth beings, emphasizing their inherent value. When the Nishnaabeg are debating over what to do about their new neighbors, a thunderbird gives them advice: “... a particular Niimkii Binesi, Echo-maker, flies over the meeting, booming and crashing, saying, ‘No, no, no. Don’t decide when you’re all mad. Don’t decide too quick. Take your time on this one. Sleep on it’” (Simpson, 60). “Niimkii Binesi” is the Anishnaabemowin word for “thunderbird,” a powerful spiritual being in Anishinaabe culture. The words “booming” and “crashing” directly reference the thunderbird’s name and association with thunder and storms. These two words also have a very powerful and authoritative connotation, emphasizing Echo-Maker’s strength. Furthermore, the advice the Echo-Maker offers to the Nishnaabeg as they fly overhead underlines their strength and knowledge. Through personification, namely giving the Niimkii Binesi both a name and a direct voice, Simpson reinforces their animacy and agency. Their name, Echo-Maker, has a commanding presence, and their voice is a demonstration of both their autonomy because they are able to express themselves. Echo-Maker’s advice to the Nishnaabeg and his astute observations about their state of mind illustrate them as a sentient, powerful being. Echo-Maker identifies what the Nishnaabeg cannot, namely that they are too agitated over their neighbors’ carelessness to make a sensible decision. Echo-Maker urges the Nishnaabeg to make a decision about the neighbors when their minds are not clouded by anger, demonstrating their emotional maturity and perceptiveness. Furthermore, throughout the book, Simpson continuously uses pronouns such as “she,” “him,” and “they” to refer to nonhuman earth beings such as animals and plants. The attribution of anthropomorphic/human-like pronouns to nonhuman earth beings imbues them with a

sense of animacy. These pronouns also serve to level the power imbalance between humans and nonhuman earth beings; in comparison to Western culture, in which nonhuman earth beings are typically referred to as “it,” using human pronouns for these earth beings creates a sense of balance and equality. Unlike in Euro-Western frameworks, the notion that nonhumans have agency and can act independently is accepted as a foundational assumption in Indigenous studies and does not have to be proven (Rosiek et al., 7). The use of pronouns that draw connections between humans and nonhuman earth beings can be a first step in preventing the use of language from justifying exploitation efforts; once we no longer view earth beings as resources to be taken, we cultivate a sense of empathy, making it harder to exploit them (Kimmerer, 2020). In this way, Simpson’s use of pronouns is not only a tool for granting animacy but also to prevent further exploitation of nature by humans. In summary, Simpson’s use of personification in the form of direct voice and pronouns reinforces the inherent agency and value of earth beings.

In addition, Simpson portrays seasons as active agents capable of influencing human behavior, rejecting Western frameworks that cast the natural world as passive. When Nanabush arrives to find the Nishnaabeg people absent in the short story “The Gift is in the Making,” he observes, “It’s ziigwan. The Nishnaabeg should be mending nets, setting nets, smoking fish. The ice is off the lake. The winter is in retreat. There should be woodpiles, fires, but, instead, there is nothing” (85). The word “ziigwan” is Anishnaabemowin for “spring.” In this passage, ziigwan is shown actively shaping how the Nishnaabeg behave. This is shown through Nanabush’s alarm when he sees the Nishnaabeg neglecting their seasonal obligations; the seasons, who are seen as active agents influencing human behavior, have been ignored, which has led to a disruption of the natural order of the world and the reciprocal relationships between the Nishnaabeg and the natural world. This further underscores the significance of the seasons and their role in shaping human action in contrast to the Western narrative of human domination over passive environmental factors. This passage demonstrates that seasons are not passive backdrops but instead are powerful actors whose movements and fluctuations significantly determine human behavior. As opposed to humans being in control of the natural world, as often seen in Western narratives (fig. 1), nature and humans work in harmony, with nature influencing and guiding human behavior. This concept is also exemplified by the phrase “winter is in retreat.” In this phrase, winter, a force typically thought of as inanimate and passive in Western culture, is portrayed not only as animate but also as actively retreating. Overall, Simpson rejects the Western portrayal of seasons and earth beings as passive, instead depicting them as active agents capable of shaping the environment and beings around them.

Finally, active voice and action-based diction are used to empower earth beings to make their own decisions. In the same short story, “The Gift is in the Making,” Nanabush observes that “the Ninaatigoog gave that syrup right out of their bodies, right over to whoever wants to drink it” (87). The term “Ninaatigoog” means “maple tree” in Anishnaabemowin. The word “gave” not only implies agency but also intention; the ninaatigoog choose to give their syrup to the Nishnaabeg, as opposed to the Nishnaabeg taking it without consent. Furthermore, the use of active voice in framing the Ninaatigoog as the subject rather than the object imbues the trees with a sense of agency and power, since they are able to make decisions for themselves. In Western frameworks, land and nature have historically only been considered with regard to how they can be used to make progress for humans (Watts 26). However, this passage proposes an alternative depiction of natural beings as possessing agency and power to give, rather than something to be exploited by humans. Moreover, this passage is also indicative of respectful relationships between humans and nature; the Nishnaabeg want the syrup, and the Ninaatigoog willingly give it to them, demonstrating how resources can be acquired without the brutality of Western culture. Ultimately, Simpson’s use of active voice and action-driven language endows earth beings with agency and the authority to make their own decisions.

Ultimately, Simpson’s use of narrative techniques such as direct speech, personification, and action-oriented diction illustrate nonhuman earth beings in their stories as powerful, knowledgeable, and revered, which imbues them with an inherent sense of authority and animacy. In the context of our research project, this text can help us better understand how portraying nonhuman earth beings with animacy and agency can promote a view of the environment that values all species equally.

3. *Mishkos Kenomagwen: The Language of TEK and Western Science*

Robin Wall Kimmerer’s *Braiding Sweetgrass* is a collection of Indigenous stories and wisdom written from the author’s perspective as a descendant of the Potawatomi tribe—a branch of Anishinaabe peoples found in the Great Plains, upper Mississippi River, and western Great Lakes region. *Braiding Sweetgrass* uses colloquial storytelling techniques and personal stories, oriented in the belief of treating living beings as autonomous individuals, to study sweetgrass through the lens of TEK. The book provides a compelling alternative to Western scientific writing, which often ignores ecological nuances.

“*Mishkos Kenomagwen: The Teaching of Grass*,” a chapter in *Braiding Sweetgrass*, is structured like a scientific research paper with sections: introduction, literature review, hypothesis, methods, results, discussion, conclusions, acknowledgements, and references cited. Instead of the impersonal,

objective language research studies usually employ, however, Kimmerer's paper uses intimate language that conveys the content of the research in a personal tone. The chapter details an investigation into the diminishing sweetgrass population. Kimmerer was the first in her tribe to observe the crisis that the elders of her tribe had failed to explain. She delegated the investigation to a graduate student, Laurie. Laurie proposed a field experiment comparing patches of sweetgrass that had undergone different harvesting methods, only for the reviewing committee to scoff at her idea. Regardless, Laurie carried on with the help of Kimmerer in the year-long research. The study found that the sweetgrass patch that was half-harvested grew best while the unharvested patch slowly died, finally convincing the faculty committee of the validity and the significance of their research. We analyze six excerpts from the chapter that best epitomize Kimmerer's ecocentric worldview, reflecting her Potawatomi upbringing.

In their research, Kimmerer and Laurie treat sweetgrass with great reverence and acknowledgement of their agency. Laurie struggles to adhere to the objective methodologies of science as the research goes on, noting the appeal of sweetgrass as a teacher rather than the subject of an investigation. Kimmerer records, "Later, she [Laurie] admitted that it was hard to stay neutral in her research and avoid affection for the plants; after so many days among them, learning and listening, neutrality proved impossible" (Kimmerer, 161). Kimmerer's explanation outlines an important imposition of Western science—the necessary objectivity of an experiment. The word "neutrality" indicates the indifferent nature of Western science, which forces its practitioners to be stripped of all emotions when analyzing the research subject. This view ignores the animacy of living beings and renders earth beings as inanimate objects. Such a perception proves problematic in that it simultaneously objectifies earth beings and grants access for human exploitation of the natural world, therefore causing the moral barrier of responsibility toward living beings to be removed. Kimmerer also illustrates the animacy and agency of sweetgrass through the use of the words "learning" and "listening," instead of language like "observing" or "analyzing" traditionally utilized by Western science. Her meticulous choice of verbs levels the relationship between humans and other earth beings; "learning" and "listening" give authority to sweetgrass instead of assuming human superiority over nature. This ecocentric perspective applied by Kimmerer and Laurie throughout their research allows for insightful findings often overlooked by anthropocentric frameworks.

Kimmerer places emphasis on the language of relationships. When describing their findings in field research, she writes, "Plants answer questions by the way they live, by their responses to change; you just need to learn how to ask. I smile when I hear my colleagues say, 'I discovered X.' That's kind

of like Columbus claiming to have discovered America. It was here all along, it's just that he didn't know it" (158). Kimmerer ties the voice of authority to exploitation, both in an environmental and colonial sense. The phrase "I discovered X" reinforces the Western method of attributing knowledge solely to one person or group, which grants a false sense of achievement to the discoverers. This practice is rooted in the celebration of ownership of both natural beings and Indigenous territories. By claiming that humans just need to "learn how to ask" plants, Kimmerer shifts the responsibility of understanding to humans, urging people to move past their uninformed confidence when studying natural phenomena. Her use of active voice by framing "plants" as the subject also grants autonomy and agency to them; she depicts plants as independent actors with their own sophistication, not just inanimate objects functioning mechanically. While doing so, Kimmerer simultaneously promotes closer observation of plants: she acknowledges the complexity found within earth beings and rejects an oversimplification of the natural world fueled by egotism. Kimmerer's respectful diction reflects a philosophy that could further Western scientific research by prompting researchers to look beyond their inherently anthropocentric assumptions.

Kimmerer's research points to the ecological importance of reciprocity between species using the language of agency. Kimmerer draws this conclusion from the study, citing the need for coexistence between organisms rather than humans' complete disengagement from the environment. She writes, "The system is well balanced, but only if the herd uses the grass respectfully. Free-range buffalo graze and move on, not returning to the same place for many months. Thus they obey the rule of not taking more than half, of not overgrazing. Why shouldn't it also be true for people and sweetgrass? We are no more than the buffalo and no less, governed by the same natural laws" (164). Her comparison of humans and buffalo draws on her underlying belief of equality between the species. Kimmerer grants the buffalo the same autonomy that is primarily reserved for humans in Western frameworks. Her statement that the herd has the responsibility of using the grass "respectfully" delegates agency to the animals. By placing all species on equal footing, Kimmerer amplifies human responsibility. She implies that other species such as buffalo are fulfilling their roles in the ecosystem by following the natural laws of the earth, yet humans are not accomplishing their part. This ecocentric narrative establishes that all species play an integral role in their respective ecosystems; therefore, it becomes hard for humans to neglect environmental and climate issues. Kimmerer's last sentence in regard to equality before nature has powerful ramifications. Her words attack environmental hubris, the idea that humans are above the laws of nature, through complete rejection of human exceptionalism.

Kimmerer also cites the spirituality of earth beings as a part of her language of respect for the natural world. She was tasked with understanding the decline of the sweetgrass population. She explains, “I want to help, but I’m a little wary. Sweetgrass is not an experimental unit for me; it’s a gift ... I’m not sure I want to force the teachings of grass into the tight uniform of scientific thinking and technical writing that is required of the academy ... But I’ve been asked on behalf of sweetgrass, and I know my responsibility” (158). Her view of the sweetgrass as a “gift” highlights the reverence she gives to the plant, as it is an irreplaceable part of Potawatomi spiritual life. Thus, she demonstrates an attitude towards sweetgrass that is neither insolent nor indifferent, instead offering attentive care to sweetgrass. With this attitude, she is able to communicate with sweetgrass spiritually, allowing her to see the problems they are facing. Kimmerer’s statement that sweetgrass “asked” her to conduct this study reflects a greater sense of purpose—rooted in the common value as earth beings. Kimmerer converts the animacy and agency of the sweetgrass into actual practice through treating sweetgrass as her equal. This sense of equality constructs the framework of the “gift economy,” which Kimmerer mentions in the earlier chapters of his book. As earth beings with animacy and agency, humans and other organisms exchange favors, ranging from providing food to aiding reproduction. This economic system based on favors, known as a “gift economy,” establishes harmonious human-earth being relationships by disengaging the psychology of exploitation—gifts are always altruistic, so one cannot take advantage of another being. Kimmerer sheds light on a potential application of the concepts of animacy and agency in building relational frameworks that could replace Western, capitalist models found at the root of environmental issues.

Lastly, Kimmerer explores the possibility of combining TEK with Western scientific frameworks through writing that encompasses both systems. Despite repeatedly noting the flaws in writing and thinking from Western science, she and Laurie nevertheless pursue the study in accordance with scientific methodologies and language, to which she describes, “Our research was most definitely grounded in theory... in the traditional ecological knowledge of indigenous peoples: If we use a plant respectfully, it will flourish. If we ignore it, it will go away. This is a theory generated from millennia of observations of plant response to harvest, subject to peer review by generations of practitioners, from basket makers to herbalists” (159). Kimmerer’s diction, composed of words like theory, observations, and peer review, reflects the integration of scientific frameworks in the study. Kimmerer confronts both Indigenous and Western frameworks by bringing one into the other, framing TEK in a way that disciples of Western science can comprehend. She merges the Indigenous languages of animacy and autonomy

with the more accepted language of Western objectivity. By denoting basket makers and herbalists as peer reviewers, she legitimizes the Anishinaabe knowledge system built upon practical empiricism. Though adapting TEK into Western science does not promote ecocentrism the way TEK alone does, it does bring TEK and Indigenous philosophies about human-environment relationships to a broader audience. Combining the two worldviews has the potential to craft a narrative of climate change based on animacy and agency that is further-reaching and more ecocentric than current options.

Overall, our analysis of these three primary texts shows how Anishinaabe authors use specific narrative and storytelling techniques to craft depictions of the natural world that reject the anthropocentric hierarchy proliferated by Western narratives. Authors of these works used themes of animacy and agency to construct more species-inclusive, ecocentric narratives and challenge dominant Western systems of thought.

V. Discussion

This project found that in Anishinaabe stories, all beings are imbued with a spirit; kinship is depicted between almost all earth beings; earth beings are portrayed as powerful, wise, and worthy of respect; and intimate writing styles confer TEK, which Western, objective scientific writing alone cannot capture. Anishinaabe authors use the techniques of personification, recognition of spirit within all beings, and personal language to depict all earth beings as animate and possessing the agency to think and act according to their own will. These stories demonstrate the Anishinaabe view of all earth beings as essential to the natural environment, rejecting the Western narrative of nonhuman earth beings as passive resources. From an Anishinaabe perspective, all earth beings are active participants in the world and have the ability to influence and shape their environment. Additionally, the Anishinaabe perspective of reciprocal and respectful relationships between all earth beings places all beings on equal footing with one another, rejecting the Western belief in human superiority over the natural world.

Our findings align with Watts (2013), who sees all beings as animate and agentive. She upholds our view on reciprocal relationships between species, claiming that Indigenous peoples think of themselves as extensions of the land they live on, and they therefore have an obligation to sustain its agency. Her claim that Indigenous communities view all species as sovereign, equal, and interconnected ties to our point that Indigenous authors promote inclusive narratives of the climate crisis through portraying all earth beings equally and respectfully. Our research also agrees with “Confronting the contradictions between Western and Indigenous science: a critical perspective on *Two-Eyed Seeing*” by

Broadhead and Howard. Both works recognize the limitations of Western approaches to ecological knowledge and argue that environmental writing incorporates Indigenous ecological language with more accuracy and nuance (Broadhead and Howard, 114). Other case studies also confirm the power of incorporating TEK with Western science (Beer and Wyk 186-187). Regardless, there still exist numerous challenges in combining the two systems of knowledge creation (Garrote 111-112), including the concern that current integration of Indigenous knowledge into Western science frameworks is disorganized (Michie et al. 7-11).

Our research suggests that Anishinaabe authors promote a more ecocentric and inclusive narrative of the environment, which translates to the climate crisis, in contrast to dominant anthropocentric narratives. By portraying all earth beings as equals and giving all beings due respect, Anishinaabe stories and literature reject the anthropocentric hierarchical structure of the environment and instead promote a narrative that values all earth beings equally, thereby challenging historical Euro-Western patterns of exploitation and dominance over nature. Our findings could help climate authors craft narratives through the use of animacy and agency of beings, which promotes empathy and respect for those that inhabit this earth. In doing so, however, writers must also attribute credit to the original Indigenous authors, and preserve nuance without generalizing intricate Indigenous knowledge systems.

In considering the limitations of our research, we acknowledge that we only analyzed three English texts written by Anishinaabe writers, which provides a very limited view of the diverse discourse and representation within the Anishinaabe group. Our findings cannot be generalized to other Indigenous cultural contexts and perspectives. Therefore, future research work should focus on studying and comparing other Indigenous languages and their environmental implications, preferably in their original language. The goal of our research is to build a repertoire of Indigenous narrative techniques that are useful in telling climate change stories; writers could harness these techniques to construct narratives that attract support and action for the climate crisis. Gaining a fuller understanding of Indigenous storytelling allows us to gain appreciation for the nuances of TEK, leading to a more sustainable human-ecological framework.

VI. Conclusion

Our research explores how Anishinaabe authors harness specific storytelling elements that promote ecocentric narratives of the climate crisis. Anishinaabe literary techniques rooted in the

animacy and agency of earth beings convey a nature-oriented storytelling that can help further conservation efforts. Specifically, we found that several characteristics are prevalent in Anishinaabe stories: earth beings are depicted as influential and revered creatures, earth beings have spirits that are interconnected, and TEK is communicated through distinctively agency-centered writing styles. Although Western language and knowledge frameworks remain the dominant force behind climate and environmental narratives today, Indigenous beliefs and philosophies like the ones behind Anishinaabe stories are rising in prominence. Indigenous literature typically promotes a more ecocentric narrative, positing humans as a component of the natural world that exists in harmony with other earth beings. We attempt to understand some perspectives within the wide range of Anishinaabe philosophies; our argument is founded upon the three pieces of Anishinaabe literature that we believe represent their ecological success. Indigenous literature is a vastly underrepresented field, and much valuable insight and practical findings can be yielded if more attention is dedicated to the study of this field.

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